

AMSS 2026 — Lab 5: Project Workshop + Checkpoint Defense

Traian-Florin Șerbănuță

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Lab 5: Workshop + Checkpoint

Two phases, 100 minutes — **the labs now turn to your own project.**

1. **Team workshop** (~60 min) — supervised project work; close the gaps you know about.
2. **Checkpoint defense** (~40 min) — each student gives a **3-minute cold defense** of their slice.

This is the **December checkpoint** — a **1-point gate** toward your project grade.

What the Checkpoint Is

- ▶ A **3-minute, cold defense** of your slice's progress — no slides required, no AI in the room.
- ▶ The instructor asks **Critique / Rationale / Traceability** questions about *your* slice.
- ▶ Worth **1 point** of the project grade. The bar is *progress and ownership*, not a finished slice.

The Three Questions (the defense rubric)

The checkpoint is the full defense rubric in miniature:

- ▶ **Critique** — “Read me this diagram from your slice. Anything wrong?”
- ▶ **Rationale** — “Why did you direct AI this way here? What did you reject?”
- ▶ **Traceability** — “Walk one requirement of your slice to a test.”

Same rubric as the Week 14 defense — this is your first live rehearsal.

What to Have Ready

By the checkpoint, your slice should show:

- ▶ A **requirement** you own, traceable into your slice.
- ▶ The **two diagrams** (structural + behavioral) in progress —
AI-generated, **reviewed by you**.
- ▶ A **defect log** started — at least a few caught defects.
- ▶ A **trace** you can walk, even if partial.

Use the Workshop Time

The first 60 minutes are supervised work. Spend them on:

- ▶ Running your **trace audit** (Week 10) — fix broken links before the checkpoint.
- ▶ **Re-reading** every AI diagram in your slice — could you critique it cold?
- ▶ Logging any **defects** you haven't yet written down.

The instructor circulates — ask for help.

What “Pass” Looks Like

You pass the checkpoint if, in 3 minutes, you can:

- ▶ **read** one of your diagrams and spot or confirm an issue (Critique),
- ▶ **say why** you directed AI a certain way (Rationale),
- ▶ **walk** one requirement-to-test trace of your slice (Traceability).

Owning your slice — not finishing it — is the bar.

If Your Slice Is Thin

Better to defend a **small, owned** slice than a large one you can't explain.

- ▶ Bring the part you understand best.
- ▶ Be honest about what's not done — honesty is a strength signal (Week 12).

The checkpoint is a safety net: it surfaces gaps while there's still time.

Submit / Record

- ▶ No new artifacts to submit — your slice lives in the **team repo** already.
- ▶ The instructor records your checkpoint result (pass / partial) on the spot.
- ▶ Partial? You get specific gaps to close before **Week 14**.

Why This Matters

The checkpoint is your **first cold defense** — the Week 14 oral defense in miniature, with a safety net.

A student who can walk their slice today walks the whole project in Week 14. Next: **Lab 6** is the full dry run.